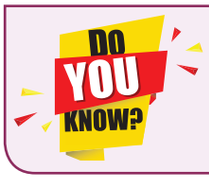
The Sun



Sun

The Sun is at the centre of the solar system. Each member of the solar system revolves around the Sun. The Sun is so huge, that it accounts for 99.8 percent of the entire mass of the solar system. The Sun is made up of extremely hot gases like Hydrogen and Helium.

The Sun is a star. It is self-luminous; it gives light on its own. The surface temperature of the Sun is about 6,000° C. It is the source of light and heat energy to the entire solar system. Sunlight takes about 8.3 minutes to reach the Earth.



1.3 million Earths can fit inside the Sun. Imagine how big the Sun is.

Planets

The word 'planet' means **wanderer**. There are eight planets in the solar system. They are Mercury, Venus, Earth, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus and Neptune. All the planets rotate anti-clockwise (from west to east) on their own axes except Venus and Uranus. The elliptical path in which the planets move around the Sun is known as orbit. The eight planets revolve in their respective orbits because of the gravitational pull of the Sun. They do not move out of their paths or away from the solar system.

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GEO CONNECT: The ancient Tamils knew that the planets revolved around the Sun. For example, in Tamil literature **Sirupanatruppadai**, the line 'வாள் நிற விசும்பின் கோள் மீன் சூழ்ந்த இளங்கதிர் ஞாயிறு' mentions that the Sun is surrounded by planets.

The four planets nearer to the Sun are called **Inner or Terrestrial Planets** (Mercury, Venus, Earth and Mars). The inner planets are comparatively smaller in size and are composed of rocks. The surface of inner planets has mountains, volcanoes and craters. The last four planets are called as **Outer Planets or Jovian Planets** (Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune). They are also called **Gaseous Giants**. An asteroid belt is found between Mars and Jupiter.

Mnemonic to remember the order of planets: My Very Educated Mother Just Showed Us Neptune.

Mercury (The Nearest Planet)



Mercury

Mercury is the smallest and closest planet to the Sun. It is named after the Roman deity 'Mercury', the messenger to the Gods. It is an airless and waterless planet. It does not have an atmosphere and so experiences extremes of temperature. It has no natural satellites. Mercury can be viewed in the morning and evening with the naked eye.

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